

Australia's animal health laboratories seek to sustain and improve the quality of terrestrial and aquatic animal health to assure domestic and international market access through the development and application of best practice to veterinary laboratory services.

The Animal Health Committee (AHC) is supported by a task group that reports to the National Biosecurity Committee (NBC) on national animal health laboratory standards and other quality assurance related functions. The task group meets on an 'as-needs' basis and its membership includes:

- the state and territory animal health laboratories
- the Australian Centre for Disease Preparedness (ACDP)
- Australian Government Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry
- Animal Health Australia (observer)
- the New Zealand Ministry for Primary Industries.

A member of the AHC chairs the group.

The task group acts as a forum for national coordination on issues such as:

- quality assurance
- new test evaluation and development, including an up-to-date test register standard diagnostic procedures
- laboratory emergency animal disease (EAD) preparedness and response
- a national reference laboratory system
- technical and policy advice relating to diagnostics, biosecurity and biosafety and related training opportunities
- laboratory disease surveillance and the [National Animal Health Information System](#) (NAHIS).

ACDP (formerly known as the Australian Animal Health Laboratory) is a Commonwealth Scientific and Industrial Research Organisation (CSIRO) national facility based in Geelong, Victoria and one of the six major high-containment animal health laboratories in the world. ACDP is designed for EAD diagnosis and research. Its diagnostic services are primarily funded by the department, including the following activities:

- providing diagnosis of and emergency response to EADs, including relevant research and surveillance works
- providing technical and scientific advice on EADs
- providing education and training in EAD recognition and diagnosis for animal health workers
- serving as a World Organisation for Animal Health (WOAH) reference centre for bluetongue, avian influenza, Newcastle disease, Hendra and Nipah virus diseases, yellowhead disease, epizootic haematopoietic necrosis, ranavirus infection, abalone herpes-like virus disease, new and emerging diseases and laboratory capacity building, a Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations (FAO) reference laboratory for biological risk management, and a national reference laboratory for brucellosis and rabies.
- maintaining and improving microbiological and physical security of the containment facility.

In addition to ACDP, the six central state or territory government laboratories and various private and university animal health laboratories support the national animal health system.

Government and major private animal health laboratories in Australia are accredited to relevant international standards (i.e. ISO/IEC 17025:2005) through the [National Association of Testing Authorities](#) (NATA), which is a member of the [International Laboratory Accreditation Cooperation](#) (ILAC) and represents Australia in ILAC activities. Accreditation through NATA provides an important mechanism for formal recognition to competent testing services, thus improving the efficiency and competitiveness of Australian animal industries in international and national markets.

AHC, through its laboratory task group, maintains a comprehensive series of disease-based Australian and New Zealand Standard Diagnostic Procedures (ANZSDPs) and publishes revisions and new titles as required, in line with WOAHP recommended procedures with requirements specific to Australian situations included.

The Australian National Quality Assurance Program (ANQAP) and ACDP facilitates is accredited to relevant international standards (i.e. ISO/IEC 17043) and provides national and international inter-laboratory proficiency testing (PT) programs for a range of important animal diseases.

These PT programs cover assays used for quarantine, export certification and national disease control, including haematology, biochemistry, parasitology, histopathology, serology, molecular (genetic) detection, and bacteriology.

The WOAHP Focal Point for Veterinary Laboratories in Australia is Dr William Wong, who is responsible for co-ordinating and reporting veterinary laboratory issues to the WOAHP through the Chief Veterinary Officer as the Australian WOAHP Delegate. Should you wish to contact him, please email [WOAHP Australia](#).

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/animal/health/system/lab-network>